Lesson 22 - How to do Service

Saturday, March 28, 2026 5:58 PM

LESSON 22 – HOW TO DO SERVICE

Spiritual Principle: Children will learn that we should do service to the best of our ability, because no act of service is too small and it is the intention that is important.

(Note to gurus: This lesson can be used for reflection after a service project planned for SSSE children.)



Human Value: Love
Inward Quality: Service

Prayers: (Select from the Prayers section.)
Meditation: Jyothi/light meditation or Soham meditation (Use script in Appendix.)
Spiritual Diary review: (Please review spiritual diary with children.)

(Note to gurus: Display Swami's Message or give the children a copy of it. Read it aloud together and then have the children read it to themselves. Give the children some time to reflect on Swami's Message. Ask them the following questions.)

Swami's Message:
"Even a small act of service done with the sole intention of pleasing God will acquire great significance."

(Sri Sathya Sai Baba, February 24, 2002)

1. What is service?
2. Can you share some examples?

Group Activity #1:
Bring a clear bin to class. Fill it half-way up with water. Put it on a flat stable surface such as a table or on the floor. Make sure the water is still and calm inside the bin. Bring a small rock or a marble. Ask one child to gently throw the rock/marble into the bin. Have the children observe the ripples in the water, going right up to the edge of the bin. Share the message

or a marble. Ask one child to gently throw the rock/marble into the bin. Have the children observe the ripples in the water, going right up to the edge of the bin. Share the message below with the students.

"If you throw a pebble into a well, ripples are created and these travel up to the edge of the well. In the same way, if you throw a pebble called good thought into the well called the heart, the ripples generated travel throughout the body. When the ripple reaches the eye, it stimulates pure vision. When the ripple reaches the ear, it tunes the latter to sacred sounds. When the ripple reaches the hands, it swings them into good action. In this manner, when the ripples spread across the entire body, there is a symphony of sacred activity all round. Thus, good and noble thoughts are fundamental to sacred activity."

(Sri Sathya Sai Baba, May 21, 2000)

(Note to gurus: Remind children again about the Buddha's noble Eightfold Path: Samyak Drishti (vision), Samyak Sankalpa (thoughts), Samyak Karma (actions), Samyak Shruthi/Shravanam (listening), Samyak Jeevan (life), Samyak Sadhana (spiritual practice), Samyak Samadhi (even-mindedness), and Samyak Vaak (speech). These eight principles highlight the sacredness of both the senses and the mind, teaching us how to use them properly to live an ideal and meaningful life. Gurus can take time to bring attention to Samyak Karma (action) and explain how Buddha emphasized Samyak Karma (goodness in action).

The mark of good action is harmony in thought, word, and deed. Pure actions lead a person to realize what is 'human quality.' These teachings are universal and reflected in other faiths too. For example, Zoroastrianism teaches the beautiful principle of "Good Thoughts, Good Words, Good Deeds." Briefly introduce these faith traditions by showing the Sarva Dharma symbol—Zoroastrian fire chalice and Buddhist wheel. As Swami so beautifully reminds us, true spirituality emphasizes the Truth that is common to all faith traditions. One must recognize the unifying Truth in all faith traditions.)

Group Activity #2:
The children participate in the service activity planned for SSSE children.

If an activity has not been planned for SSSE children at the center, the children can plan for a service activity themselves. They can pick a seva and note down the steps needed to execute it. They can make a checklist to plan for it. They can think about things to keep in mind during seva. They should also keep some time to reflect after the activity. This may be done individually or in groups. Planning for a service activity is an activity in itself.

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Discussion:

(Note to gurus: These questions are for reflection and can be used for discussion after the children do a service project.)



1. What service project did we do in the last class?
2. Who will this service help? (others and yourself)
3. How will this help others?
4. How will this help us?
5. How did this make you feel?
6. What went well?
7. What could we have done differently?
8. How can you continue to do small acts of seva everyday—at home or at school?

(Note to gurus: Display Swami's Message or give the children a copy. Read it aloud together and then have the children read it to themselves. Give the children some time to reflect on Swami's Message. Ask them the following questions.)

Swami's Message:

"Was it beyond the power of Rama to discover Sita in Lanka Himself? What need was there for Him to send Hanuman? Rama wanted Hanuman to go on the search, so that He could show to the world the devotion and steadfastness and faith of Hanuman. It is a case of Grace on the part of Rama.

In the same manner, if Sai so much as wants to do so many things Himself, He could do anything. It is done through these Seva Organisations so that members of the organization get the chance to do service and redeem themselves.

The basic purpose of all service activities is to effect a transformation from the state of man to the state of Divinity. Fill your hearts with that which is godly. Then there will be meaning to your volunteer service."

(Sri Sathya Sai Baba, July 14, 1984)

1. Now that you have read this, what do you think of what Swami says?
2. Which line stands out to you?

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Story #1:
When Ravana kidnapped Sita and took her to Lanka, Hanuman helped find her. He leaped across the ocean with Rama's name in his heart and reached Lanka.

When the time came for Rama and his army of monkeys to cross the ocean, it was decided to build a bridge. The monkeys brought huge rocks and threw them into the sea to build a passage across for Rama and His army. The work was going on day and night, in full swing when it was seen that a tiny squirrel was also trying to help, the best it could. It rolled on the sands on the seashore, ran toward the heap piled as part of the passage, and whisked the sand from its fur by a vigorous shake, though adding only a pinch of material to the quantity heaped by the giant monkeys.





Rama saw the squirrel and appreciated its devotion. Even though the quantity of sand it bought was little compared to the huge rocks and boulders bought by the monkeys, the squirrel was putting in its best effort to help in Rama's work.He took it fondly on His palm, stroked its back tenderly and blessed it. That was an ample reward for it. The squirrel has since acquired three lines on its back, indicating that sign of Lord Rama's gratification and grace.

(Sri Sathya Sai Baba, January 13, 1968)

1. How did the squirrel's help in building the bridge compare to that of the monkeys?
2. What qualities was the squirrel exhibiting?
3. What was Rama's response to the squirrel's actions?

Story #2:
Once Jesus performed penance on a mountain after securing the permission of his mother. As a result of this, he realized his Self. He then prayed to God, "Oh Father! Grant me three boons."

What were the three boons he prayed to God for? The first boon he asked God was, "You have given me this life. I should use this life to serve all without causing harm to anyone. I should always be ready to forgive. But I should never endorse untruth. Lead me to the path of truth." This was the first boon he prayed for.

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The second boon he prayed for was, "People may criticize me, make fun of me, hurt me, ridicule me, or harm me out of their jealousy; grant me the heart which can hear all this with fortitude; grant me the boon that my heart should remain peaceful even if jealous people subject me to any number of sufferings." People become jealous to see the progress, prosperity, and happiness of others. This is the sign of man's narrow-mindedness. The heart which harbors jealousy cannot truly be called a human heart. Even animals do not bear so much jealousy as does modern man. Since the selfishness of man today has increased enormously, his jealousy has also become too much.

The third boon he asked God was, "Oh Lord! Fill my heart with love, so that I can share my love with all and devote my life to serve You and love You wholeheartedly. You are the embodiment of love; I should also become full of love like You."

(Sri Sathya Sai Baba, June 18, 1996)

1. What do you think of the three boons asked by Jesus?
2. Which boon stands out for you?
3. If you were to ask God for one of these three boons, which one would you choose?
4. What boons do you ask from God?

Spiritual Diary: (Use template from Appendix. Give reminders & motivate children.)
Bhajans: (Select from the Bhajan section)
Prayers: (Select from the Prayers section)

(Note to gurus: Remind children to continue working on their presentations about themselves and their families. This can include where their parents are from, where they are from, information about themselves, and special traditions that their family participates in.)